INNOVATR INSIGHTS REPORT

Cutting Back, But Not on Snacks

The New Non-Negotiable Treat

Insights that drive results

Executive Summary

Even with wallets under severe pressure, South Africans are making it clear: snacks are not up for debate. At-home treats have become daily essentials, serving as affordable pick-me-ups amid economic uncertainty. This resilience in snacking behaviour has big implications for how brands connect and stay relevant in consumers' lives.

Business Implications

Brands that position themselves as providers of accessible comfort and joy—rather than luxuries—will win in this climate. The opportunity lies in understanding the emotional role snacks play as daily rewards in South African homes.

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The Surprising Reality

Conventional Wisdom

When budgets tighten, luxuries like snacks are the first items cut

"Economic pressure means consumers eliminate non-essential purchases and focus only on necessities."

VS

The New Reality in South Africa

Snacks remain non-negotiable despite financial pressure

"A R10 chocolate or packet of chips serves as a crucial mood-lifter that consumers aren't willing to sacrifice."

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Key Data: Snacks Are Non-Negotiable

Budget Priorities

80%

of consumers say they always find room in their budget for snacks, no matter how tight money gets.

KEY INSIGHT

Snacks have become non-negotiable items in South African homes, transforming from luxury to essential purchase.

"Families might buy cheaper staples or stretch meals, yet still insist on their favourite biscuits or a premium ice cream for Friday nights."

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Key Data: Indulgence as Well-being

Emotional Health

75%

believe a small daily treat is "more important than ever" for their well-being amidst today's stresses.

Source: Innovatr research

KEY INSIGHT

Treats have evolved beyond indulgence to become essential emotional support mechanisms in challenging times.

"In stressful times, small daily rewards offer moments of joy and normalcy that consumers aren't willing to sacrifice, regardless of economic pressure."

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Key Data: The Pull of Nostalgia

Childhood Memories

72%

would pay extra to bring back their favourite childhood snack brands.

Source: Innovatr research

KEY INSIGHT

In uncertain times, emotional connections to past memories become more valuable, creating powerful opportunities for heritage brands.

"The comfort of familiar childhood treats becomes a powerful emotional anchor during periods of financial and social instability."

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Behavioural Insights

Younger Adults

- Seek novel flavours and excitement
- Value social experiences through snacking
- Use snacks as stress relief and distraction
- Excited by limited editions and new products

Older Adults

- Prefer comfort and familiar favourites
- Strong pull toward nostalgic brands
- Value consistency and trusted quality
- See snacks as ritual and tradition

Cross-Demographic Insights

- Across income levels, households cut back elsewhere but protect the 'treat fund'
- Emotional motivation: Snacks serve as reward, comfort, and daily escape
- Strategic indulgence: Consumers make conscious trade-offs to afford small treats

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Strategic Implications for Marketers

Turn insights into action with these targeted approaches

Position

Frame snacks as essential daily rewards—not just luxuries. Marketing should affirm the emotional benefit (comfort, stress relief, joy) that your product delivers during challenging times.

Leverage

Tap into trust and nostalgia to foster brand loyalty. Highlight your brand's longevity and quality or resurrect classic flavours to create emotional connections with consumers seeking familiarity.

Innovate

Create new flavours, formats, or limited-time offers to generate excitement, especially among younger consumers who crave variety, while balancing novelty with the familiar tastes people trust.

Develop

Offer accessible price points through smaller pack sizes or value combo deals for family snacking. Make it easy for budget-conscious consumers to say "yes" to your product as an affordable luxury.

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Innovatr Expertise

Consumer Research

Our proprietary methodologies uncover the deep motivations behind consumer behavior, delivering insights that traditional research misses.

Strategic Workshops

Interactive sessions that transform data into actionable strategies, tailored to your brand's unique challenges and opportunities.

Trend Analysis

We contextualize South African consumer behaviors within global trends, helping you anticipate shifts before your competitors.

Category Expertise

Specialized knowledge across FMCG, retail, financial services, and telecom sectors with a deep understanding of local market dynamics.

> At Innovatr, we connect brands directly to what South Africans want—practically and emotionally—in the moments that matter. Our insights don't just inform; they inspire action and drive measurable results.

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Action & Next Steps

Explore Your Category Performance

See how consumers respond to your product idea, packaging or messaging within 24 hours using Test24's rapid insight engine.

Pay-Per-Idea Testing

Turn questions into answers fast. Test online at only R5,000 per idea, get instant answers

Research, Your Way!

If you need more than a quick read, we can build a focused Test24 study to explore segments, pricing, claims, benefits or creative routes in detail.

Ready to make your brand a must-have comfort in South African homes?

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